

Lenition in Prasun

Intervocalic lenition is among the most common recurrent sound changes cross-linguistically. The Middle Indo-Aryan lenition, which involved the voicing, spirantisation and eventual complete elision of intervocalic single stops and affricates, spread areally throughout the Indian subcontinent and has left reflexes in all contemporary Indo-Aryan and Nuristani languages. Despite considerable variation in their outcomes, these developments were restricted to word-internal positions, as is typologically expected for lenition processes, in all languages apart from Prasun, a Nuristani language spoken in the Hindu Kush.

Though the segmental outcomes of lenition are similar to those of the other Nuristani languages, the conditioning is different: Prasun lenites not only intervocalically, but also in word-initial position: $/*p/$, $/*b/ > /w/$; $/*k/$, $/*g/ > \emptyset$; $/*t/ > /j/$; and $/*d/ > /l/$, regardless of their position in the word, merging voiceless and voiced stops except in the dental series, where an early shift of $/*d/ > /l/$ bled its expected lenition to $/j/$. Affricates are similarly unconditionally lenited, merging the voiced and voiceless series ($/*tʃ/$, $/*dʒ/ > /z/$; $/*tʃ/$, $/*dʒ/ > /z/$), which has no direct parallels in the other Nuristani languages.

This lenition caused Prasun words to look very different from their cognates in other Nuristani languages, e.g. Katë $/ʔotr/$, Ashkun $/cātr/$ but Prasun $/zi't(ː)əy/$ ‘spindle’ ($< *čātstra-$), or Katë NE $/pjas'jū/$, Ashkun $/pjaũ/$, but Prasun $/wa'si/$ ‘Prasun’ ($< *pārusnī-$).

The outcome of the word-initial and the intervocalic lenition is the same, so we assume that these developments resulted from the same lenition process. The question we would like to answer is: what is it about Prasun that made it behave differently from all other Indo-Iranian languages with regard to the conditioning of lenition processes?

To approach this question, we will draw on evidence from sound change typology and phonetic typology, suggesting an explanation based on the role of gemination contrasts in a pre-Prasun stage.

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